



Identifying molecules

Complementary Vibrational Spectrometer can now be used to study how molecules vibrate, and thus, identify them. <https://digit.in/oct19-75>



Fighting fake news

WhatsApp has restricted the number of times a message can be forwarded to fight fake news but to little effect. <https://digit.in/oct19-76>

Sony WH-XB900N

An affordable, bass-heavy alternative to the acclaimed Sony WH-1000XM3

Existing as a bridge between Sony's Extra Bass series and the much-acclaimed Sony WH-1000XM3, the Sony WH-XB900N attempts to provide something of value to numerous kinds of consumers at a lower price point than the exorbitantly-priced WH-1000XM3. On paper, the Sony WH-XB900N has a lot to offer, but does it translate well? Let's find out.

Build and design

The build of the Sony WH-XB900N is reminiscent of the Sony WH-1000XM3, but you will 'feel' the difference since they feel much more plasticky.

The left earcup houses a 3.5mm audio socket to accommodate the 3.5mm cable. It also features a USB-C charging port, one of the microphones, an NFC logo and two physical buttons – a power button and a customisable button. The customisable button can be assigned as an ANC profile controller or to activate your preferred voice assistant. On the right-hand side, the earcup houses another microphone and an embedded touch-sensitive panel on top of the earcup.

Overall, the Sony WH-XB900N are extremely comfortable to wear, even over long periods of usage. They sport an inconspicuous and clean design.

Features

The headphones come equipped with ANC (Active Noise Cancellation), however, the calibre of this technology is miles away from the WH-1000XM3, which is far superior. Isolation, when ANC is turned on, is extremely disappointing, especially in the bass range which renders it unsuitable for commute. However, the ANC performance indoors is starkly different since it works extremely well in office environ-



PERFORMANCE.....	74
DESIGN	77
FEATURES.....	70

ments. This suggests that ANC does well in blocking out the middle-range and treble external sounds, such as the voices of our noisy editorial team.

The headphones also boast an accompanying app – Sony | Headphones Connect, home to a plethora of features and customisations.

One such feature is Adaptive Sound Control which detects your surroundings and actions using its microphones and AI capabilities to set an ambient mode. The modes include – Staying, Walking, Running, and Transport.

The feature works quite well, with it detecting staying (indoors), walking and running extremely accurately. However, when it came to Transport, it had trouble detecting when we were on a train.

These cans also have a feature called Quick Attention mode which lets you momentarily pay attention to your surroundings by placing your palm on the right earcup.

The touch-sensitive controls are extremely responsive and easy-to-use. Lastly, Sony has incorporated support for an array of Bluetooth codecs such as

aptX, aptHD, LDAC and more, which will thrill audiophiles.

Performance

Staying true to the 'XB' moniker, the Sony WH-XB900N are ridiculously bass-heavy and we found the bass levels to be jarring and unpleasant at times.

The headphones have a warm sound signature and the mids and vocals seem to be quite recessed due to this.

There's an excess of thump and rumble of bass in almost every genre, even the ones that aren't meant to feature it. The fine details in non-bass instruments are relegated to the background, making the sound very one-dimensional.

The highs are not very pleasant (can get shrill) and the response is quite uneven. You can witness this in *Serotonina* by *Highly Suspect*, at the 2.38 mark.

Coming to battery life, the cans lasted about 29 hours with ANC being turned on for about two-thirds of that time. The headphones took around 4 and a half hours to charge from near empty, which is a tad slower than expected but it is nothing unmanageable. Wireless range and connection stability are both stellar on these headphones, despite only having Bluetooth 4.2 instead of 5.0.

Bottomline

The Sony WH-XB900N is an affordable alternative to the more expensive Sony WH-1000XM3, and it does compromise on audio quality. The sound signature, while it may be ideal for bass-heads, is a bit too bass-y and muddy to the average consumer and especially the audiophile. The headphones do offer a host of features though. However, the isolation in ANC mode is disappointing. Overall, if you want a pair of wireless headphones that concentrates heavily on booming bass, these may be the cans for you.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

WEIGHT: APPROX. 254 G | HEADPHONE TYPE: DYNAMIC | DRIVER: 40 MM | IMPEDANCE: 50 OHM | FREQUENCY RESPONSE: 20 Hz–20,000 Hz | NFC: YES | BATTERY CHARGE TIME: APPROX. 7 HRS | BATTERY LIFE: MAX. 30 HRS (NC ON), MAX. 35 HRS (NC OFF) | BLUETOOTH VERSION: VERSION 4.2 | RANGE: 30 FT | SUPPORTED AUDIO FORMATS: SBC, AAC, aptX, aptX HD, LDAC

CONTACT

SONY INDIA | PHONE: 1800-103-7799 | EMAIL: Live Chat on website | WEBSITE: www.sony.co.in